

As I Was Saying BOB INGRAM SPORTS EDITOR

Threadbare Bench

OLD MOTHER HASKINS went to the bench to get his poor team a player . . .

Before the UTEP coach said it at the Monday Touch-down Club meeting, there had been suspicions that the Miners right now don't have the bench they had in their national championship season.

Everything looked rosy that way when the season opened. Then Bobby Joe Hill's use was curtailed through injuries and other problems and finally canceled out entirely. Then Willie Worsley had his right hand hurt in the Chicago snowstorm game with Brigham Young and it hasn't been right for shooting purposes since then. He re-injured it early against Seattle Saturday night, was taken out of the game and didn't get back until just before it ended.

Suddenly, Haskins finds himself cut down to six front line operatives and two of those are sophomores.

The Miner bench was of good quality and fairly deep a year ago. Haskins had seven men whom he used in close games. That gave him a starting five and two top flight reserves. In addition he had two players who got to play quite a bit in games that were not close. They were David Palacio and Jerry Armstrong. Neither played in the championship game against Kentucky but Armstrong got into the semi-final game against Utah by necessity when four Miner regulars got into first-half foul troubles and did an outstanding job.

As I said, Haskins was fairly deep and had quality.

He was lucky to escape the serious injury bugaboo. The Miners haven't been so fortunate this season.

2 Able Guards

THE MINERS had guards running out of their Memorial Gym at the start of the season. They had four with Hill, Worsley, David Palacio and Kenny John. Now, they're down to two who are physically fit.

The guards get the ball into the inside men and they take pot shots at the basket when they're open and can set for them.

Worsley has his hot nights, like the performance against West Texas when he hit for 34 points. Palacio and John each have hit well on occasions.

However, the Miners haven't had too much outside power. Orsten Artis was a clutch long distance shooter. He had some cold nights, too.

There's a look toward John Ruud, a 6-foot freshman guard, who's from Azusa, Calif. He's a good long distance shooting hope of the future.

Inside Buildup

SOME OF THE most interesting Haskins comments at the TD meeting included:

UTEF will need more inside strength next season.

The Miners' morale is good. Those tough games on the road are bound to help them improve.

The biggest problem is lack of consistent shooting. "As Andy Cohen (baseball coach) knows, a .250 hitter remains a .250 hitter."

(The only thing a coach can do, I suppose, is to teach the fundamentals of shooting and let 'em practice and practice. If the players then can't hit a ton of goals they never will.)

The UTEP coach used the zone mainly at Tulsa to keep his big men out of trouble. It didn't stop his big men from getting into foul difficulties at Seattle. He quit it and went into the man-for-man before the half was up.

He gave indications that he may not go back to the zone this season. "I like to know," he said, "who's responsible for letting any opposing player score against us. In the man-for-man, there's more individual responsibility than in the zone."

The Miners tried to catch up too quickly against Seattle. "When you're behind, you should have more patience and poise. Then it's time to run your offense better and more smoothly."

Haskins believes the crowd enthusiasm here is a degree or two off from last season and that the 28-1 season and a national championship may have spoiled some of the fans who think the team should never lose.

"Maybe 10 years from now I'll look back and think a 16-4 record at this time of the season was an outstanding one."

Haskins is paying the price of winning a national championship. He'll agree whatever happens, it's worth it.